

EXPERIENCES OF MOTHERHOOD

Child's play

Motherhood has traditionally been portrayed as a woman's greatest role, often to the detriment of all other possible achievements. Even today, as most mothers work outside the home, mothers still tend to spend more of their time on childcare than fathers.

ALTHOUGH ICONIC MOTHER figures have long featured in world mythology and popular culture, from Medea in ancient Greece to the Hindu mother god Kali, ancient laws recognized the father as head of the family. Bearing children is natural, but motherhood itself is a social construction that has been defined in various ways by societies over time. Most often women were assigned primary roles as wives and mothers but were still regarded as inferior beings.

Until the idea of the nuclear family—the basic social unit consisting of two parents and dependent children—became popular in the 15th century West, mothers were not expected to raise children alone. They had help from the extended family—grandmothers, aunts, or sisters; younger family members cared for siblings, too. For example, Enawenê-nawê Indians, in the Amazon rainforest, left infants to the care of ten-year-old children, with

“The **mother puts a breast** in the **child's mouth**, but not **sense** in its **head**.”

FINNISH AND ESTONIAN PROVERB

“Remember that **nine months I bore you in my womb ... I placed you in your cradle ... and with my milk I nursed you.**”

AN AZTEC MOTHER TO HER DAUGHTER, 16TH CENTURY



mothers returning from chores to breastfeed. Where extended families did not exist, they were created from the wider community.

This practice continues today in southwest Siberia where “structural babushkas” invite young families to live with them. The older women provide childcare for the working parents, and in return are accorded a place in the family, and care in old age.

Feeding and nursing

If a mother was unable to breast-feed or died in childbirth, a wet-nurse, another nursing mother, was employed. The Qur'an stressed the importance of wet-nursing, and even today, under Islamic law one

◀ Baby transport

A Kootenai cradleboard made of wood, deer hide, glass beads, and conch shells. Portable baby carriers were important in allowing Native American mothers to work or travel.